

An Act

ENROLLED SENATE
BILL NO. 1778

By: Pugh of the Senate

and

Hilbert, Staires,
Hasenbeck, Caldwell (Chad),
Wolfley, Roberts, Hill, and
Williams of the House

An Act relating to the Strong Readers Act; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508A), which relates to the Strong Readers Act; updating statutory reference; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B, as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508B), which relates to legislative intent; stating legislative intent regarding a multi-tiered system of supports framework and core literacy instruction; requiring schools to integrate other core subjects into reading, writing, and math; defining term; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C, as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), which relates to assessments for reading skills; modifying purpose of screening; directing the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability to evaluate and rank certain number of screening instruments; directing the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability to approve certain instruments; directing the State Board of Education to select one screening instrument; requiring the instrument to meet certain criteria; removing language providing for the approval of three screening instruments; removing language regarding requirements for a program of reading instruction; directing a reading intervention plan to identify intensity of instruction; prohibiting certain

services from occurring during math instruction; expanding students who will be provided certain reading intervention plan; adding member to Student Reading Proficiency Teams; removing language regarding certain notification of parents and legal guardians; directing the State Board of Education, in certain consultation, to annually define and set certain benchmarks for screening instrument results; directing the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability to analyze and report certain tiers; prohibiting reading intervention from being provided solely by digital technology; requiring reading intervention to include certain amount of direct instruction; removing certain exemption for students who demonstrate proficiency on certain screening instrument from programs of reading instruction; modifying language regarding intensive intervention services for certain third-grade students; requiring certain first- and second-grade students to be placed in certain transitional classroom or provided certain targeted intervention instruction; allowing certain first- and second-grade students to be voluntarily retained with certain written consent; requiring families of certain first- and second-grade students to be provided certain tutoring or summer reading options; directing the State Department of Education to approve certain tutoring programs; directing the Department to make certain assessment available to school districts beginning in certain school year; requiring school districts to administer certain assessment to students in certain grade; providing for certain prior written notification; allowing written notice to opt out of certain assessment; exempting certain students who score at certain level from certain retention requirements; prohibiting performance on certain assessment from being counted against certain grading; directing school districts to use performance data for certain purpose; modifying type of intervention services to be provided to certain students; modifying information to be included in certain notification for parents and legal guardians; providing for certain

intervention services for certain incoming third-grade students; requiring third-grade students to demonstrate sufficient reading skills beginning in certain school year; providing methods for demonstration; requiring retention of certain third-grade students; prohibiting screening instruments from being used for promotion purposes; providing good-cause exemptions to retention; providing good-cause exemption request process; requiring written notification of parents and legal guardians of retained students; subjecting certain students to certain screening and testing upon return to a public school; prohibiting certain receiving school from altering certain third-grade retention requirements for a student who transfers; directing retained students to be provided certain interventions beginning in certain school year; requiring school districts to review certain intervention plans; requiring school districts and the State Department of Education to report certain information; updating statutory language; updating statutory references; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D, as amended by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508D), which relates to appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers Act; modifying language regarding calculation of certain allocation; providing for calculation of base literacy allocations; providing purpose of base literacy allocation; providing for calculation of supplemental weighted funding; providing purpose of supplemental weighted funding; requiring school districts to maintain certain documentation; providing for promulgation of certain rules; allowing the State Department of Education to require certain documentation or provide certain assistance under certain circumstances; directing a portion of certain funds to be provided as incentives for school districts demonstrating certain improvement; removing certain stipend; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E, as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508E), which relates to summer academy programs; allowing a

teacher to recommend certain tutoring; directing academy programs to incorporate certain reading intervention services and be taught by certain individuals; requiring school districts to provide certain intervention options to certain students; requiring summer academies to consist of certain amount of instructional time; prohibiting summer academies from including certain instruction models; requiring, rather than allowing, certain intervention to be expanded to certain grade; requiring school districts to report certain information to the State Board of Education; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F, as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), which relates to reading competencies for teacher education programs; allowing professional development to include certain components; requiring teacher candidates to study certain negative impacts, identification of certain models, and how to implement certain instruction; requiring certain teacher education programs to be audited for certain compliance; directing noncompliant programs to be placed on certain status and given certain guidance; amending Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L. 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), which relates to literacy instructional teams; removing pilot program language; directing the State Department of Education to employ literacy coaches who are placed in certain number of regions; providing duties of coaches; providing for priority placement of coaches; requiring coaches to pass certain test; increasing number of coaches; providing additional criteria for coaches; providing for assignment of coaches; exempting a school district that employs certain coaches from using certain literacy coaches if they participate in certain coaching improvement community; modifying criteria for individuals to be given certain preference; prohibiting certain school districts that decline certain assistance from being eligible to receive certain funding; requiring school districts to have certain staff member at each public

elementary school; directing the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, in certain collaboration, to develop certain teacher training academies for certified personnel to provide certain micro-credential; requiring certain teacher training academies to be held prior to the 2026-2027 school year; providing certain stipend for receiving an early literacy micro-credential; providing certain funding amount for certain public and private institutions of higher education; creating the Strong Readers Revolving Fund; specifying sources of fund; providing for expenditures; providing purpose of fund; allowing donors to the fund to designate certain recipient; providing for codification; and declaring an emergency.

SUBJECT: Reading instruction in schools

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508A), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508A. Sections 1210.508A through ~~1210.508H~~ 1210.508J of this title shall be known and may be cited as the "Strong Readers Act".

SECTION 2. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B, as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508B), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508B. A. The Legislature finds that it is essential for children in the public schools to read early and well in elementary school. The Legislature further finds that clear and visible goals, assessments to determine the reading level at each elementary school, use of a scientifically based and researched methodology in reading instruction in addition to regular and periodic measurements of elementary school reading improvement, and

accountability in each level of the educational system will result in a significant increase in the number of children reading at or above grade level.

B. The purpose of the Strong Readers Act is to ensure that progression from one grade to another is determined, in part, upon proficiency in reading, that school district board of education policies facilitate reading instruction and intervention services to address student reading needs, and that each student and his or her parent or legal guardian be informed of that student's reading progress. It is the intent of the Legislature that every student reads at or above grade level by the end of third grade.

C. To carry out the purpose of this act, it is the intent of the Legislature that the identification, instruction, and intervention required under the Strong Readers Act be implemented within a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework that emphasizes strong core literacy instruction for all students and provides increasing levels of instructional intensity based on student need and demonstrated response to instruction.

D. It is further the intent of the Legislature that strong core literacy instruction consists of explicit, systematic instruction in foundational reading and writing skills including phonological awareness, decoding, encoding, spelling, sentence-level writing, language development, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, recognizing the reciprocal relationship between reading and writing proficiency.

E. Each public school district in this state shall ensure that all students receive a well-rounded education that is focused on building deep foundations in reading, writing, and mathematics. The State Board of Education shall ~~encourage~~ require school districts to integrate the teaching of the other curricular areas in the subject matter standards adopted by the Board with the instruction of reading, writing, and mathematics. All teachers of reading in the public schools in this state in kindergarten through third grade shall ~~incorporate into instruction the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension~~ provide systematic and explicit instruction in the five elements of reading, which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, using

high quality instructional materials grounded in the science of reading, selected from a list of approved materials maintained by the State Board of Education.

~~D.~~ F. It is the intent of the Legislature that beginning with the 2025-2026 school year, school districts and charter schools in this state shall be prohibited from using the three-cueing system model of teaching students to read. For the purposes of this section, the "three-cueing system" means any model of teaching students to read based on meaning, structure, syntax, and visual cues, which may also be known as meaning, structure, and visual (MSV), balanced literacy, or whole language.

SECTION 3. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508B-1 of Title 70, unless there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

A. As used in the Strong Readers Act:

1. "Grade-level targets" means the grade-specific benchmark scores established for the screening instrument selected by the State Board of Education in coordination with the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability;

2. "Highly qualified teacher" means a teacher or provider with appropriate training and demonstrated competency in evidence-based reading intervention;

3. "Literacy coach" means an educator with demonstrated expertise in evidence-based literacy instruction who provides job-embedded professional learning, modeling, observation, and feedback to teachers to strengthen core instruction and intervention practices within a multi-tiered system of supports framework. The primary responsibility of a literacy coach is to support educators and administrators in improving instructional practices and schoolwide literacy systems. A literacy coach shall not serve in a supervisory or evaluative capacity to maintain a nonevaluative role that fosters professional trust and growth;

4. "Multi-tiered system of supports" or "MTSS" means a framework that provides strong core literacy instruction to all

students and increasingly intensive levels of instructional support based on student need and demonstrated response to instruction;

5. "Reading deficiency" means performance below grade-level targets on a screening or diagnostic assessment indicating that a student is not meeting grade-level expectations in one or more reading skill areas;

6. "Reading interventionist" means an educator trained in evidence-based reading instruction who provides supplemental or intensive intervention to students identified with a reading deficiency or significant reading deficiency, aligned to student data and delivered in addition to core instruction;

7. "Reading specialist" means an educator who has completed advanced preparation in literacy instruction and assessment and is responsible for designing, delivering, and monitoring targeted and intensive reading intervention services, as well as supporting teachers in addressing reading deficiencies across grade levels. A reading specialist shall have completed a graduate-level specialist degree in reading or literacy and passed the applicable certification examination and shall hold a valid teaching certificate with a reading specialist endorsement;

8. "Science of reading" means the body of scientifically based research conducted over several decades and across multiple countries, drawing from multiple disciplines including cognitive psychology, linguistics, neuroscience, and education, that explains how individuals learn to read and write. The science of reading informs instructional practices that are explicit, systematic, and cumulative, and are aligned to the development of phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, written expression, and oral language development;

9. "Significant reading deficiency" means a reading deficiency that persists despite supplemental intervention and indicates a need for intensive intervention based on student data and response to instruction;

10. "Tier 1 - Core Instruction" or "Tier 1" means:

- a. the evidence-based reading instruction provided to all students as part of the general education program. Tier 1 instruction shall include high-quality, standards-aligned literacy instruction grounded in the science of reading and delivered during the regular instructional day,
- b. Tier 1 shall include universal screening in kindergarten through third grade and ongoing assessment used to identify students who may require additional instructional support. Tier 1 may also include targeted instructional supports delivered within the core instructional setting to address emerging reading needs, and
- c. Tier 1 instruction is intended to meet the needs of the majority of students through strong classroom instruction and prevention-focused supports;

11. "Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention" or "Tier 2" means:

- a. targeted reading intervention provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction for students identified through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring additional instructional support to meet grade-level reading expectations. Tier 2 intervention shall:
 - (1) provide additional instructional time beyond Tier 1 core instruction,
 - (2) be delivered in small-group settings, typically consisting of three to five students, using evidence-based instructional practices aligned with the science of reading,
 - (3) target specific skill deficits identified through assessment data, and
 - (4) include regular progress monitoring to determine the effectiveness of the intervention and guide instructional adjustments, and

- b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 2 supplemental intervention only when the student is actively participating in scheduled intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction; and

12. "Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention" or "Tier 3" means:

- a. individualized or highly targeted reading intervention provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction and Tier 2 supplemental intervention for students demonstrating a significant reading deficiency. Tier 3 intervention shall:
 - (1) provide substantially increased instructional intensity and frequency beyond Tier 2 supports,
 - (2) be delivered in individualized or small group settings, typically consisting of one to three students,
 - (3) be guided by diagnostic assessment to address specific reading skill deficits, and
 - (4) include frequent progress monitoring to evaluate student response to intervention and guide instructional decision-making, and
- b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 3 intensive intervention only when the student is actively participating in scheduled intensive intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction.

B. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules establishing implementation guidance for each tier defined in paragraphs 10 through 12 of subsection A of this section including expectations related to instructional time, group size, documentation requirements, and progress-monitoring practices necessary to ensure the effective delivery of intervention services.

SECTION 4. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C, as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508C. A. To identify students who have a reading deficiency or characteristics of dyslexia that lead to or cause reading difficulty, each student enrolled in kindergarten and first, second, and third grade in a public school in this state shall be screened at the beginning, middle, and end of each school year for monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension. ~~A screening instrument approved by the State Board of Education, in consultation with the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and the Secretary of Education, shall.~~ The Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall evaluate and rank up to three screening instruments, which shall be approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability. The State Board of Education shall select one screening instrument approved by the Commission to be utilized for the purposes of this section.

The selected screening instrument shall meet the following criteria:

1. Can assess for phonological awareness, sound-symbol recognition, alphabet knowledge, rapid naming skills, decoding and encoding skills, oral reading accuracy and fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as developmentally appropriate;

2. Can document the validity and reliability of each assessment;

3. Can identify students who are at risk for reading and math deficiency and monitor student progress throughout the school year;

4. Can be linked to, and can accurately predict, performance on the Oklahoma School Testing Program;

5. Is normed beyond elementary grades;

6. Can assess students with disabilities and English language learners;

7. Is accompanied by a data management system that provides profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building. The profiles shall identify the instructional point of need and reading achievement level for each student; and

8. Is capable of reporting student-level data to the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability.

B. In determining which screening instrument to approve and utilize, the State Board of Education, the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary State Board of Education shall take into consideration at a minimum the following factors:

1. The time required to conduct the screening instrument with the intention of minimizing the impact on instructional time;

2. The timeliness in reporting screening instrument results to teachers, administrators, and parents and legal guardians of students; and

3. The integration of the screening instrument into reading and math curriculum.

~~B. Beginning in the 2025-2026 school year, the State Board of Education shall approve no fewer than three screening instruments for use at the beginning, middle, and end of the school year for monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills as required in subsection A of this section. The screening instruments shall meet the following criteria:~~

~~1. Assess for phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension;~~

~~2. Document the validity and reliability of each assessment;~~

~~3. Can be used for identifying students who are at risk for reading deficiency and progress monitoring throughout the school year;~~

~~4. Can be used to assess students with disabilities and English language learners; and~~

~~5. Accompanied by a data management system that provides profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building. The profiles shall identify each student's instructional point of need and reading achievement level. The State Board shall also determine other comparable reading assessments for diagnostic purposes to be used for students at risk of reading failure; and~~

4. The ability to report all reading and math screening results to both the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability.

C. 1. Exemptions to the screening requirements of this section may be provided to students who have documented evidence that they meet at least one of the following criteria as related to the provision of classroom instruction:

- a. the student participates in the Oklahoma Alternate Assessment Program (OAAP) and is taught using alternate methods,
- b. the student's primary expressive or receptive communication is sign language,
- c. the student's primary form of written or read text is Braille, or
- d. the student's primary expressive or receptive language is not English, the student is identified as an English learner using a state-approved identification assessment, and the student has had less than one (1) school year of instruction in an English-learner program.

2. A public school that grants an exemption pursuant to paragraph 1 of this subsection shall provide ongoing evidence of student progression toward English language acquisition with the same frequency as administration of screening assessments. Evidence may include, but not be limited to, student progression toward OAAP

reading essential elements, proficiency in sign language and reading comprehension, and proficiency in Braille and reading comprehension.

D. 1. Students who are administered a screening instrument pursuant to subsection A of this section and are found not to be meeting grade-level targets shall be provided a ~~program of reading instruction designed to enable students to acquire the appropriate grade-level reading skills. The program of reading instruction shall be based on scientific reading research and align with the subject matter standards adopted by the State Board of Education. A program of reading instruction shall include:~~

- a. ~~sufficient additional in-school instructional time for the acquisition of phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,~~
- b. ~~if necessary and if funding is available, tutorial instruction after regular school hours, on Saturdays, and during summer; however, such instruction may not be counted toward the one-hundred-eighty-day or one-thousand-eighty-hour school year required in Section 1-109 of this title,~~
- c. ~~assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring to measure the acquisition of reading skills including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as identified in the student's program of reading instruction,~~
- d. ~~high-quality instructional materials grounded in scientifically based reading research, and~~
- e. ~~a means of providing every family of a student in prekindergarten, kindergarten, and first, second, and third grade access to free online evidence-based literacy instruction resources to support the student's literacy development at home intervention plan, which shall identify the needed intensity of instruction to remedy the student's specific reading deficiency as quickly as possible.~~

2. The reading intervention services required by this subsection shall not occur during math instruction.

3. A student enrolled in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who exhibits a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency at any time based on the screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section and any fourth-grade student promoted for good cause pursuant to subsection L of this section shall receive an individual reading intervention plan no later than thirty (30) days after the identification of the ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency. The reading intervention plan shall be provided in addition to ~~core~~ Tier 1 reading instruction that is provided to all students. The reading intervention plan shall:

- a. describe the ~~research-based~~ reading intervention services and the needed intensity of instruction the student will receive to remedy the ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency,
- b. provide explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as applicable,
- c. monitor the reading progress of each student's reading skills throughout the school year and adjust instruction according to the student's needs, and
- d. continue until the student is determined to be meeting grade-level targets in reading based on the screening instruments instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section or assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring ~~pursuant to subparagraph c of paragraph 1 of this subsection~~ by the State Board of Education.

~~3.~~ 4. The reading intervention plan for each student identified with a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency shall be developed by a Student Reading Proficiency Team and shall include supplemental instructional services and supports. Each team shall be composed of:

- a. the parent or legal guardian of the student,

- b. the teacher assigned to the student who had responsibility for reading instruction in that academic year,
- c. a teacher who is responsible for reading instruction and is assigned to teach in the next grade level of the student, ~~and~~
- d. a certified reading specialist or interventionist, certified personnel with an early literacy micro-credential, or an individual with advanced training or specialization in literacy instruction, if one is available and
- e. the principal, vice principal, or designate.

~~4. 5. A school district shall notify the parent or legal guardian of any student in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who exhibits a deficiency in reading at any time based on the screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section. The notification shall occur no later than thirty (30) days after the identification of the deficiency in reading. The State Board of Education, in consultation with the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, shall annually define and set benchmarks for screening instrument results that are predictive of future performance on the state summative assessment to assist in identifying intervention tiers within a reading intervention plan. Annually, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall analyze and report to the State Department of Education the correlation of screening instrument tiers to state summative tiers using predictive modeling and prior year formative and summative testing results.~~

6. Reading intervention shall not be provided solely by digital technology. Reading intervention shall include a majority of direct instruction from a teacher or reading specialist trained in the science of reading.

E. 1. Every school district shall adopt and implement a district strong readers plan which has had input from school administrators, teachers, and parents and legal guardians, and if

~~possible a reading specialist, interventionist or certified personnel with an early literacy micro-credential, and which shall be submitted electronically to and approved by the State Board of Education. The plan shall be updated annually if changes have been made to the plan. School districts shall not be required to electronically submit the annual updates to the Board if the last plan submitted to the Board was approved and expenditures for the program include only expenses relating to individual and small group tutoring, purchase of and training in the use of screening and assessment measures, summer school programs, and Saturday school programs. If any expenditure for the program is deleted or changed or any other type of expenditure for the program is implemented, the school district shall be required to submit the latest annual update to the Board for approval. The district strong readers plan shall include a plan for each site which includes an analysis of the data provided by the Oklahoma School Testing Program and other reading assessments utilized as required in this section, and which outlines how each school site will comply with the provisions of the Strong Readers Act.~~

2. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules for the implementation and evaluation of the provisions of the Strong Readers Act. The evaluation shall include, but not be limited to, an analysis of the data required in subsection ~~4~~ 5 of this section.

F. 1. ~~Any first-grade, second-grade, or third-grade student who demonstrates proficiency in reading through a grade-level appropriate screening instrument approved pursuant to subsection B of this section shall not require a program of reading instruction or an individual reading intervention plan. After a student has demonstrated proficiency through a screening instrument, the district shall provide notification to the parent or legal guardian of the student that he or she has satisfied the requirements of the Strong Readers Act. The district shall continue to monitor the student in the next successive grade level to ensure he or she maintains proficiency.~~

~~2. Beginning with the 2025-2026 school year, if a third-grade student is identified at any point of the academic year as having a significant reading deficiency, which shall be defined as not meeting grade-level targets on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section, the district shall provide~~

~~the student with intensive intervention services for the appropriate amount of the instructional day consistent with the individual reading intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 2 of subsection D of this section and as determined by the Student Reading Proficiency Team. Intensive intervention services shall continue until the student demonstrates proficiency at his or her grade level based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section.~~

~~G. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year:~~

- ~~a. if a first-grade student has demonstrated the need for reading intervention services and is not meeting grade-level targets by the end of the first grade:~~
 - ~~(1) the district shall place the student in a stand-alone transitional second-grade classroom or promote the student to second grade while providing targeted Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention instruction, or~~
 - ~~(2) the first-grade student may be subject to voluntary retention in first grade with the written consent of the student's parent or legal guardian, and~~
- ~~b. if a second-grade student has demonstrated the need for reading intervention services and is not meeting grade-level targets by the end of the second grade:~~
 - ~~(1) the district shall place the student in a stand-alone transitional third-grade classroom or promote the student to third grade while providing targeted Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention instruction, or~~
 - ~~(2) the second-grade student may be subject to voluntary retention in second grade with the written consent of the student's parent or legal guardian.~~

2. If a student is subject to the provisions of paragraph 1 of this subsection, the family of the student shall be provided with the option for the student to attend a summer tutoring program or a summer reading academy. The State Department of Education shall also approve one or two online or workbook-based summer tutoring programs for use by students under this paragraph. School districts shall also provide the parents or legal guardians of the student with a list of summer literacy programs available if a summer academy, as described in Section 1210.508E of this title, is not offered by the school district.

3. a. Beginning in the 2027-2028 school year, the State Department of Education shall make available to school districts the statewide third-grade English Language Arts assessment required by Section 1210.508 of this title, and school districts shall administer the assessment to students in second grade. School districts shall provide prior written notification to parents and legal guardians of second-grade students who will be administered the English language arts assessment, and the notification shall include information on how a parent or legal guardian may provide written notice to opt his or her student out of the assessment administration. Second-grade students who score at the proficient level or above on the assessment shall be exempt from the third-grade retention requirements provided in subsection K of this section. A second-grade student's performance on the assessment shall not be counted against him or her in classroom grading.

b. School districts shall use student performance data on the assessment administered pursuant to this paragraph to inform intervention decisions.

G. Each school district shall annually report in an electronic format to the State Department of Education, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary of Education the number of students in kindergarten through third grade per grade level who exhibit grade-level reading proficiency, the number of students per grade level who received intensive Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention services pursuant to ~~paragraph 2 of subsection F~~

D of this section, the number of students per grade level who attended a summer academy as provided for in Section 1210.508E of this title, the number of students per grade level who exhibited improved reading proficiency after completion of ~~intensive reading~~ intervention services, and the number of students per grade level who are still in need of ~~intensive reading~~ intervention services. The State Department of Education shall publicly report the aggregate and district-specific numbers submitted pursuant to this subsection on its website and shall provide electronic copies of the report to the Governor, Secretary of Education, President Pro Tempore of the Senate, Speaker of the House of Representatives, and to the respective chairs of the committees with responsibility for common education policy in each legislative chamber.

H. The parent or legal guardian of any student who is found to have a reading deficiency ~~and is not meeting grade-level reading targets~~ and has been provided a ~~program of reading instruction~~ intervention plan as provided for in paragraph 1 of subsection D of this section shall be notified in writing ~~of no later than thirty~~ (30) days after the identification of the reading deficiency. The notification shall be accompanied by the individual reading intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 3 of subsection D of this section. The notification shall include the following:

1. That the student has been identified as having a ~~substantial deficiency in reading~~ deficiency;

2. A description of the current services that are provided to the student pursuant to subsection D of this section;

3. A description of the proposed ~~intensive reading~~ intervention services and supports that will be provided to the student that are designed to remediate the identified area of reading deficiency as provided for in ~~paragraph 2 of subsection F~~ D of this section;

4. That the parent or legal guardian shall be informed in writing of the progress of the student toward grade-level reading at least every thirty (30) days and provided with strategies to assist at home;

5. That if the child's reading deficiency is not remediated by the end of third grade, the child shall not be promoted to fourth grade unless a good-cause exemption is met;

6. That a student who is promoted to the fourth grade for good cause shall receive ~~supplemental intensive~~ Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention services unless he or she is a student who meets the definition of a student with the most significant cognitive disabilities;

~~5.— Strategies~~ 7. A description of the specific skill deficits of the child and strategies for parents or legal guardians to use in helping their child succeed in reading proficiency; and

~~6.~~ 8. The grade-level performance scores of the student; and

9. That while the statewide English Language Arts assessment is the initial determinate for promotion, students may be provided with an alternative reading assessment option that is recommended by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and approved by the State Board of Education to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth grade.

I. No student may be assigned to a grade level based solely on age or other factors that constitute social promotion.

J. 1. Any incoming third-grade student identified with a reading deficiency shall be provided Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention services to remedy his or her specific reading deficiency. Intervention services shall include effective instructional strategies to accelerate student progress and be delivered by a highly qualified teacher.

2. Public school districts shall review individual reading intervention plans for all incoming third-grade students identified with a reading deficiency. The review shall address additional supports and services the student will receive. The supports and services shall include reading instruction and reading intervention services and supports to correct any identified area of reading deficiency.

K. 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, third-grade students shall demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth grade. Students shall be provided the following options to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth grade:

- a. scoring above the below basic level on the third-grade statewide English Language Arts assessment, or
- b. earning an acceptable score on an alternative standardized reading assessment as recommended by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and approved by the State Board of Education.

2. If the third-grade student cannot demonstrate sufficient reading skills on one of the two options described in paragraph 1 of this subsection and does not qualify for a good-cause exemption, the student shall be retained in the third grade for the next school year. Screening instruments described in this section shall not be used for promotion purposes.

L. The school district board of education may only exempt students from mandatory third-grade retention, as provided in subsection K of this section, for good cause. A student who is promoted to fourth grade with a good-cause exemption, except for students who meet the definition of a student with the most significant cognitive disabilities, shall continue to receive reading intervention services that includes specific reading strategies prescribed in the student's individual reading intervention plan until the deficiency is remedied. The school district shall assist schools and teachers with the implementation of reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving reading among students with reading difficulties. Good-cause exemptions shall be limited to the following:

1. Students with disabilities whose individualized education program (IEP) indicates that participation in the statewide student assessment system is not appropriate, consistent with state law;

2. Students identified as English language learners who have had less than two (2) consecutive school years of instruction in an English-learner program;

3. Students with disabilities who participate in the statewide English Language Arts assessment and who have an IEP that reflects that the student has received reading intervention for more than two (2) school years but still demonstrates a reading deficiency, or who was previously retained for one (1) year in kindergarten, first, second, or third grade; and

4. Students who have received reading intervention services for two (2) or more years but still demonstrate a reading deficiency, and who were previously retained in kindergarten, first, second, or third grade for a total of two (2) years. No student shall be retained twice in third grade.

M. Requests to exempt students from the mandatory third-grade retention requirement, as provided in subsection K of this section, using one of the good-cause exemptions, as described in subsection L of this section, shall be made consistent with the following:

1. Documentation shall be submitted from the student's teacher to the school principal indicating that the promotion of the student is appropriate. Such documentation shall consist only of the good-cause exemption being requested and the existing reading intervention plan or IEP;

2. The school principal shall review and discuss the recommendation for exemption with the student's teacher. If the principal determines that the student meets one of the good-cause exemptions based on the discussion and documentation provided, the school principal shall make such recommendation in writing to the school district superintendent. The school district superintendent shall accept or reject the school principal's recommendation in writing; and

3. The parents or legal guardians of a third-grade student eligible for a good-cause exemption may choose that the student be retained for one (1) year even if the school district superintendent accepts a recommendation for a good-cause exemption pursuant to this subsection.

N. The school district shall provide written notification to the parent or legal guardian of any student who is retained. Such

notification shall state that his or her child has not met the reading level required for promotion to the fourth grade, the reasons the child is not eligible for a good-cause exemption, and that his or her child will be retained in third grade. The notification shall include a description of the proposed reading intervention services and the intensity of instruction that will be provided to the child to remedy the identified areas of reading deficiency in the retained year.

0. 1. Students that are withdrawn from public school to bypass third-grade retention requirements, as outlined in subsection K of this section, shall be subject to screening upon return to the public school system to determine appropriate grade level upon re-entry.

2. If a third-grade student subject to retention as provided for in subsection K of this section transfers to a public school district, a charter school, or a virtual charter school, the requirements to retain the student in third grade shall not be altered by the receiving school.

P. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, students retained under the provisions of subsection K of this section shall be provided Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading interventions to remedy the student's specific reading deficiency. The reading intervention services shall include effective instructional strategies to accelerate student progress. Each school district shall conduct a review of student reading intervention plans for all students retained in third grade. The review shall address additional supports and services needed to remedy the identified areas of reading deficiency and ensure the following are provided to retained students:

1. A teacher with appropriate training and demonstrated competency in evidence-based reading intervention. School districts with only one third-grade teacher are exempt from the requirements of this paragraph;

2. Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading intervention services and supports to correct the identified areas of reading deficiency;

3. One of the following intervention supports:

- a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental research-based reading intervention delivered by a teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or
- b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that participating students successfully complete grade-level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness; and

4. A "Read at Home" plan as created by the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall be outlined in a parental or legal guardian notification, including participation in parent or legal guardian training workshops or regular parent-guided or legal guardian-guided home reading activities which are aligned to scientifically based reading research.

Q. 1. Each school district board of education shall annually publish on the school website and report electronically to the State Department of Education, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary of Education by September 1 of each year the following information on the prior school year:

- a. the policies and procedures adopted by the school district board of education to implement the provisions of this section. The information submitted shall include expenditures related to implementing the provisions of this section, the number of staff implementing the provisions of this section, and average daily classroom time devoted to implementing the provisions of this section,
- b. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in kindergarten through third grade who ~~did not meet grade-level targets~~ demonstrated a reading deficiency based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section,
- c. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in kindergarten through third grade who have been enrolled in the district for fewer than two (2) years,

- d. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in kindergarten through third grade who were retained,
- e. by grade, the number and percentage of students in kindergarten through third grade who demonstrated grade-level proficiency based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section, ~~and~~
- ~~e.~~
- f. by grade, the number and percentage of students in kindergarten through third grade who are on an individualized education program (IEP) in accordance with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) and who demonstrated grade-level proficiency based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section or an alternative assessment prescribed by the student's IEP,
- g. the number and percentage of all students in third grade who demonstrated sufficient reading skills for promotion to the next grade on the alternative reading assessment,
- h. the number and percentage of students in third grade who were promoted to fourth grade for good cause and the applicable good-cause exemption specified in subsection L of this section, and
- i. the performance of fourth-grade students on the statewide English Language Arts assessment who were promoted with a good-cause exemption in the previous school year.

2. The State Department of Education shall establish a uniform format for school districts to report the information required in this subsection. The format shall be developed with input from school districts and shall be provided not later than ninety (90) days prior to the annual due date. The Department shall annually compile the information required, along with state-level summary information, and electronically report the information to the

public, the Governor, the Secretary of Education, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives and shall post such information on its website.

3. If a school district fails to report screening instrument data to the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability as required by this subsection, such district shall not be eligible to receive funds pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

~~K.~~ R. The State Department of Education shall provide technical assistance as needed to aid school districts in administering the provisions of the Strong Readers Act.

~~L.~~ S. On or before January 31 of each year, the State Department of Education shall electronically submit to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, the Speaker of the House of Representatives, and members of the committees with responsibility over common education in both houses of the Legislature a Strong Readers Report which shall include, but is not limited to, trend data detailing three (3) years of data, disaggregated by student subgroups to include economically disadvantaged, major racial or ethnic groups, students with disabilities, and English language learners, as appropriate for the following:

1. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in kindergarten through third grade determined to be at risk for reading difficulties compared to the total number of students enrolled in each grade;

2. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in kindergarten who continue to be at risk for reading difficulties as determined by the year-end administration of the screening instrument required in subsection A of this section;

3. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in kindergarten through third grade who have successfully completed their program of reading instruction and are reading on grade level as determined by the results of a screening instrument ~~instruments~~ administered pursuant to subsection A of this section;

4. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and percentage of students that meet or do not meet grade-level targets for reading based on a screening instruments instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section;

5. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and percentage of students that were retained in third grade;

6. The amount of funds received by each district for implementation of the Strong Readers Act;

~~6.~~ 7. An evaluation and narrative interpretation of the report data analyzing the impact of the Strong Readers Act on students' ability to read at grade level;

~~7.~~ 8. The type of reading instruction practices and methods currently being used by school districts in the state;

~~8.~~ 9. Socioeconomic information, access to reading resources outside of school, and screening for and identification of learning disabilities for students not reading at the appropriate grade level in kindergarten and first through third grade;

~~9.~~ 10. By grade level, the types of intensive intervention efforts being conducted by school districts for students who are not on an IEP and who are not reading at the appropriate grade level and for students who are on an IEP and who are not reading at the appropriate grade level; and

~~10.~~ 11. Any recommendations for improvements or amendments to the Strong Readers Act.

The State Department of Education may contract with an independent entity for the reporting and analysis requirements of this subsection.

~~M.~~ T. Copies of the results of the screening ~~instruments~~ instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section shall be made a part of the permanent record of each student.

SECTION 5. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D, as amended by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508D), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508D. A. ~~Contingent on the provision of appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers Act, school districts may be allocated monies for each enrolled kindergarten student or first-, second-, and third-grade student of the current school year who is found to be in need of remediation or intensive intervention services in reading. The allocation shall be distributed to each school district upon approval of the strong readers plan for the school district by the State Board of Education and the submittal of a child-count report to the State Department of Education that details the number of students identified as needing remediation or intensive intervention services in reading. To determine a per-student allocation amount, the total amount of funds available for allocation each year shall be divided by the total number of students in the state identified as in need of remediation or intensive intervention services in reading as provided for in Section 1210.508C of this title. Each school district shall be allocated an amount equal to the per-student allocation amount multiplied by the number of identified students enrolled in the school district.~~

B. ~~Beginning with the 2022-2023 school year, districts receiving more than Two Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$2,500.00) pursuant to subsection A of this section shall spend no less than ten percent (10%) to provide professional development for teachers teaching prekindergarten through grade five. The professional development shall include training in the science of reading including how students learn to read; training in providing explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension; implementing reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving reading among students with reading difficulties; and instructional materials required for implementation.~~

C. ~~By June 30, 2022, the Department shall approve and publish a list of professional development programs that are evidence-based and directly address the cognitive science of how students learn to read for which districts are permitted to use the funds received under this section~~ each school district shall receive a base

literacy allocation calculated on a per-student basis for each student enrolled in kindergarten and grades one through three, as reported in the October 1 enrollment counts of the current school year.

The base literacy allocation shall support the prevention of reading deficiencies and the implementation of strong core literacy instruction within Tier 1 of a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework, including, but not limited to:

1. Evidence-based core literacy instruction and instructional materials aligned with the science of reading;

2. Universal screening and diagnostic assessment necessary to identify students at risk for reading deficiencies;

3. Progress monitoring and data use to inform instructional decisions;

4. Family literacy resources and engagement activities aligned with classroom instruction; and

5. Professional development and instructional coaching necessary to implement the district strong readers plan.

The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than forty percent (40%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to support the base literacy allocation described in this subsection.

B. 1. In addition to the base literacy allocation provided pursuant to subsection A of this section, school districts shall receive supplemental weighted funding for students identified through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring additional reading intervention services within a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework.

2. Supplemental weighted funding shall support intervention services beyond Tier 1 core instruction and shall be distributed according to the following categories:

a. Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention Weight: Students identified as requiring targeted reading intervention

beyond core instruction shall generate supplemental funding to support additional instructional time, reduced group size, and evidence-based intervention, and

- b. Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention Weight: Students identified as demonstrating a significant reading deficiency requiring intensive, individualized, or highly targeted intervention shall generate supplemental funding reflecting the increased instructional intensity required at this level.

3. Supplemental funding received pursuant to this subsection shall be used exclusively for intervention services beyond Tier 1 core instruction, including:

- a. additional instructional time devoted to reading intervention,
- b. reduced instructional group sizes necessary to deliver intensive instruction,
- c. specialized instructional materials and intervention programs aligned with the science of reading,
- d. compensation for educators delivering intervention services, and
- e. professional development necessary to ensure educators providing intervention services have extensive training in the science of reading.

4. The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than thirty percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to support supplemental weighted intervention funding described in this subsection and shall promulgate rules establishing the methodology for calculating weights, documentation requirements, and procedures for verifying intervention participation.

5. Students shall be counted for purposes of supplemental weighted funding pursuant to this subsection only when the school district has documented and electronically reported to the State

Department of Education that the student is receiving intervention services consistent with the level of instructional intensity required at the applicable tier.

6. School districts shall maintain documentation demonstrating:

- a. identification of the student through an approved universal screening assessment and supporting diagnostic or progress-monitoring data,
- b. implementation of an intervention plan specifying the instructional approach, frequency, duration, and group size of intervention services, and
- c. ongoing progress monitoring used to determine the effectiveness of the intervention and inform instructional adjustments.

7. Students shall not generate supplemental weighted funding unless intervention services are provided beyond Tier 1 core instruction. The State Department of Education may review intervention documentation and program implementation to verify eligibility for supplemental weighted funding distributed pursuant to this section.

8. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules establishing reasonable expectations for the proportion of students receiving supplemental and intensive intervention services within a multi-tiered system of supports framework.

9. When the reported percentage of students receiving Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention services significantly exceeds expected ranges, the State Department of Education may require additional documentation or provide technical assistance to ensure intervention services are implemented with the instructional intensity required at each tier.

C. 1. In order to encourage continuous improvement in student reading outcomes and to support the sustainability of effective intervention services, a portion of funds appropriated pursuant to this section shall be used to provide incentives to school districts demonstrating measurable improvement in student reading performance.

2. Incentive funding may include recognition of:

- a. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit Tier 3 intensive intervention,
- b. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit Tier 2 supplemental intervention, and
- c. schools or districts demonstrating measurable reductions in the number or percentage of students requiring supplemental or intensive intervention.

3. The State Board of Education shall allocate up to thirty percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section for literacy improvement incentives and shall promulgate rules establishing criteria for determining eligibility for such incentives.

~~D. If a teacher attends and completes a professional development institute in elementary reading approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability during the summer or when school is not in session, the teacher may receive a stipend equal to the amount of the cost for a substitute teacher, based on the amount of funds allocated.~~

SECTION 6. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E, as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508E), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508E. A. If a teacher determines that a student in kindergarten or first through third grade is not reading at grade level by the end of the second quarter of the school year, the parent or legal guardian of the student shall be notified of:

- 1. The reading level of the student;
- 2. The program of reading instruction for the student as required pursuant to the Strong Readers Act; and

3. The potential need for the student to participate in a summer academy or other program designed to assist the student in attaining grade-level reading skills.

B. A teacher who determines a student in kindergarten or first through third grade is not meeting grade-level targets for reading may, after consultation with the parent or legal guardian of the student, recommend that the student participate in and complete a transitional instructional setting, before-, during-, or after-school supplemental tutoring, a summer academy program, or other program.

C. Summer academy programs shall be designed to ensure that participating students successfully complete grade-level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness. A summer academy reading program shall be a program that incorporates ~~the content of a scientifically research-based professional development program administered by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability or a scientifically research-based reading program administered by the State Board of Education~~ reading intervention services and is taught by ~~teachers who have successfully completed professional development in the reading program or who are~~ a highly qualified teacher, a certified as reading specialists specialist, interventionist, or certified personnel with an early literacy micro-credential. The program shall provide explicit, systematic, sequential, and cumulative reading intervention services and supports to correct students' identified areas of reading deficiency.

D. School districts may approve an option for students who are unable to attend a summer academy. The optional program may include, but is not limited to, an approved private provider of instruction, approved computer- or Internet-based instruction, or an approved program of reading instruction monitored by the parent or legal guardian. School districts shall not be required to pay for the optional program but shall clearly communicate to the parent or legal guardian the expectations of the program and any costs that may be involved.

E. ~~Subject to the availability of funds, beginning 1.~~ School districts shall provide at least one of the following Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading intervention options to all third-grade students scoring

at the below basic achievement level on the third-grade statewide English Language Arts assessment, as well as students who have completed kindergarten through second grade and are at risk of reading deficiency as determined by a screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of Section 1210.508C of this title:

- a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental research-based reading intervention delivered by a teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or
- b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that participating students successfully complete grade-level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness.

2. Summer reading academies shall include, at a minimum, seventy (70) hours of instructional time in reading and shall not use balanced literacy and whole language models, such as three-cueing as defined in subsection F of Section 1210.508B of this title.

F. Beginning one (1) year after implementation of this section, the requirements of subsection ~~B~~ E of this section ~~may~~ shall be expanded to apply to students in fourth grade. Each year thereafter, the requirements ~~may~~ shall be expanded by one grade level until the requirements apply to third-grade students through eighth-grade students. ~~Summer academy programs~~ The reading intervention options outlined in subsection E of this section shall be designed for each grade level. Nothing in this section shall prevent the State Board of Education or a school district board of education from utilizing private, local, or federal funds to implement this section.

~~F. G.~~ The State Board of Education shall adopt rules to implement the provisions of this section ~~which shall include requirements for instructional time for summer academy programs, teacher qualifications, and evaluation of student achievement as a result of summer academy programs or other optional programs~~ and shall require school districts to report statewide assessment data aggregated to the classroom level, on the availability of reading intervention options, the number of students participating in each

option, and evaluation of student achievement as a result of each provided option.

SECTION 7. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F, as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508F. A. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall ensure that the reading competencies for elementary teachers are included in the competencies for special education teachers.

B. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability in collaboration with the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education shall ensure that all teachers ~~and adjuncts~~ of early childhood education, elementary education, and special education are provided quality training in intervention, instruction, and remediation strategies in the science of reading to provide explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension and implement reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving reading among students with reading difficulties. Professional development may include effective use of data, progress monitoring, and intervention planning as it fits into a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework. In addition, quality education for prospective teachers shall be provided in research-based instructional strategies for instruction, assessment, and intervention for literacy development for all students including advanced readers, typically developing readers, and struggling readers who are coping with a range of challenges including, but not limited to, English language learners, students at risk for reading deficiencies, and ~~learners~~ students with handicapping conditions and learning disabilities, including dyslexia. Quality training shall include guidance from professional resources such as the Report of the National Reading Panel, Response to Intervention guidelines, and professional organizations such as the Council for Exceptional Children, International Dyslexia Association, International Literacy Association, National Council of Teachers of English, and National Association for the Education of Young Children.

C. All institutions within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education that offer elementary, early childhood education, or

special education programs approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall incorporate into those programs the requirement that teacher candidates study the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension and study methods based on the science of reading. Teacher candidates shall study strategies including, but not limited to, instruction that is explicitly taught, sequenced, multimodal (reading, writing, speaking, listening, hands-on, etc.), multidisciplinary, and reflective to adapt for individual learners. Additionally, teacher candidates shall study the negative impacts of balanced literacy and whole language models, including three-cueing practices. They shall further study how to identify balanced literacy and whole language models including three-cueing practices in curriculum, and subsequently, learn how to implement reading instruction using high-quality instructional materials grounded in the science of reading which do not include balanced literacy and whole language models such as three-cueing.

D. Each teacher education program approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall be audited by the Commission to ensure teacher candidates are receiving quality training in the science of reading. The Commission shall place the accreditation of any noncompliant teacher education program on probationary status and provide guidance for exiting probationary status.

E. Effective July 1, 2025, any person seeking initial certification in a special education, early childhood education, or elementary education program in this state shall be required to successfully complete a comprehensive reading instruction assessment approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability as a condition for certification. The assessment shall be aligned to scientifically based reading research and evaluate the certification applicant's knowledge and understanding of the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension.

~~E.~~ F. Candidates applying for adjunct positions, an alternative placement teaching certificate, or an emergency teaching certificate in elementary education shall complete instruction in the science of

reading as determined by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and the State Board of Education.

SECTION 8. AMENDATORY Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L. 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508H. A. Beginning with the ~~2023-2024~~ 2026-2027 school year, the State Department of Education shall establish and maintain a ~~three-year pilot~~ program to employ ~~a literacy instructional team~~ coaches to support school districts in implementation of the requirements of Section 1210.508C of this title. The Department shall provide technical assistance for literacy instruction, dyslexia, and related disorders, and serve as a primary source of information and support for schools, administrators, and teachers in addressing the needs of students struggling with literacy, reading deficiencies, or dyslexia, and related disorders or identified with the risk characteristics associated with dyslexia.

B. The Department shall employ ~~a literacy instructional team with team members~~ coaches who are placed ~~regionally~~ in six major geographic regions across the state. The literacy ~~instructional teams~~ coaches shall assist schools, administrators, educators, and general education and special education teachers in recognizing educational needs to improve literacy outcomes for all students including those with reading deficiencies or dyslexia or identified with the risk characteristics associated with dyslexia. Priority shall be given to the lowest performing schools on the end-of-year English Language Arts assessment or the statewide reading screener as approved by the State Department of Education. The role of the literacy ~~instructional team~~ coaches shall also include increasing professional awareness and instructional competencies to meet the educational needs of all students including those with reading deficiencies or dyslexia or identified with risk characteristics associated with dyslexia. The Department shall prioritize supports and interventions including enrollment in reading trainings and professional development for schools which have the highest percentage of students who do not demonstrate sufficient reading skills as established by the State Board of Education.

C. Literacy coaches shall provide systems and instructional support to schools to strengthen the implementation of evidence-based literacy instruction and intervention and to build the capacity of educators and school leaders to sustain effective literacy practices. Literacy coaches shall serve in a supportive, nonevaluative capacity and shall not conduct personnel evaluations or impose personnel actions.

D. ~~Literacy instructional team members~~ coaches employed by the Department shall be required to pass Oklahoma's Foundations of Reading test and shall have training in:

1. The science of how students learn to read including phonological awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, writing, and language;

2. Foundation of multisensory, explicit, systematic, and structured reading instruction;

3. Identification of and the use of appropriate interventions, accommodations, assistive technology, and teaching techniques for struggling students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading disorder, or reading deficiency;

4. The requirements of the Strong Readers Act;

5. Special education laws and procedures; and

6. Appropriate interventions, accommodations, and assistive technology supports for students with dyslexia or a related disorder.

~~D.~~ E. The literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed by the Department shall report to the Program Director for Literacy at the Department and ~~have:~~

~~1. A~~ shall consist of a minimum of five ~~twenty~~ regional literacy ~~leads~~ coaches, at least one who shall be designated by the Department as a dyslexia specialist to provide school districts with support and resources that are necessary to assist students with dyslexia. The Department shall give preference to educators applying for regional literacy ~~lead~~ coaches who:

1. a. hold a master's degree in education with three (3) years of documented successful experience teaching reading as evidenced by reading assessment scores, or
b. hold a bachelor's degree with five (5) years of documented successful experience teaching reading as evidenced by reading assessment scores with a minimum of three (3) years of literacy experience at the state, district, or school level;

2. Have a valid certificate to teach issued by the State Board of Education;

3. Have experience delivering professional development specific to literacy instruction, mentoring and coaching classroom teachers, leading others in a collaborative process, and analyzing and using student performance data for instructional purposes;

~~have~~ 4. Have an endorsement or certification as a certified structured literacy dyslexia specialist or certified academic language therapist;

~~b. are~~

5. Are knowledgeable of multitiered systems of support; and

~~c. have~~

6. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use of appropriate interventions and treatment models for, accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, and

~~2. A minimum of ten literacy specialists, a related reading disorder, or reading deficiency.~~

F. 1. The State Department of Education shall assign literacy coaches to school districts that are identified by the Department based on the number and percentage of students scoring in the below basic performance level on the statewide third-grade assessment

administered pursuant to Section 1210.508C of this title or the statewide reading screener in kindergarten through second grade.

2. If a district already employs instructional coaches, that district shall not be required to utilize Department-assigned literacy coaches so long as the local instructional coaches participate in a Department-led coaching improvement community aligned to the science of reading and national coaching best practices.

G. Literacy coaches assigned to school districts pursuant to the provisions of this section shall:

1. Provide technical support to teachers responsible for reading instruction and reading specialists and interventionists;

2. Assist administrators, educators, and reading specialists and interventionists in implementing evidence-based literacy practices;

3. Design and conduct professional development to meet the needs of teachers and administrators in the area of literacy;

4. Provide clear, practical, timely, and candid written and oral feedback to teachers and administrators based on coaching cycles; and

5. Meet regularly with teachers, reading specialists and interventionists, and administrators to review literacy data and make recommendations for adjustments in instructional practices.

H. The Department shall give preference to educators applying for ~~literacy specialist~~ to become a literacy coach who:

~~a.~~ have

1. Have training in the science of reading~~r~~;

~~b.~~ are

2. Are knowledgeable of ~~multitiered~~ multi-tiered systems of support~~, and~~;

e. have

3. Have been trained in the identification of and intervention for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice the use of appropriate interventions and treatment models for, accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading disorder, or reading deficiency; and

4. Have previously retired and were a highly effective elementary school teacher based on student reading scores on the statewide English Language Arts assessment or teacher evaluations.

I. If a school district that is prioritized for supports and interventions pursuant to this section declines to accept assistance from a literacy coach, the district shall not be eligible to receive funds pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

J. 1. School districts shall have a minimum of one reading specialist, interventionist, or teacher with an early literacy micro-credential for each public elementary school.

2. For school districts that do not currently employ or contract with a reading specialist or interventionist, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, in collaboration with the State Department of Education, shall work with public or private institutions of higher education within this state to develop teacher training academies for certified personnel to obtain an early literacy micro-credential. The academies shall provide a competency-based professional learning micro-credential after completing an intensive teacher training academy held at Oklahoma-based institutions of higher education.

3. The teacher training academies developed pursuant to paragraph 2 of this subsection may include in-person instruction, synchronous online, or hybrid options. The intensive academy shall be focused on MTSS, the science of reading, and standards alignment for early literacy instruction in kindergarten through third grade. Districts shall select at least one member of certified school personnel per school, with priority given to districts without a current full- or part-time reading specialist or interventionist,

per year to attend the teacher training academies. Such individuals may be any certified school personnel who will work with students in kindergarten through third grade.

4. The Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall set program criteria for the micro-credential course and vet higher education programs seeking to issue the credential to Oklahoma educators. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall approve higher education institutions allowed to issue an early literacy micro-credential. Both public and private higher education institutions may apply. The first teacher training academy shall be held prior to the 2026-2027 school year.

5. Instructors for teacher training academies shall possess relevant field experience including demonstrated recent practice in the field.

6. For each member of certified school personnel who will work with grades kindergarten through three who receives an early literacy micro-credential pursuant to the provisions of this subsection, the State Department of Education shall provide:

- a. a stipend of Three Thousand Dollars (\$3,000.00) to the certified personnel who receives the early literacy micro-credential, and
- b. One Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$1,500.00) to the public or private higher education institution approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability to issue the micro-credential.

~~E.~~ K. The State Department of Education shall electronically submit a report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives by December 31, 2026, that includes an evaluation of the pilot program by school districts, data on whether the program had an impact on increasing the number of students who demonstrate proficiency in reading, and recommendations for changes to the Strong Readers Act.

SECTION 9. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508J of Title 70, unless there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

A. There is hereby created in the State Treasury a revolving fund for the State Department of Education to be designated the "Strong Readers Revolving Fund". The fund shall be a continuing fund, not subject to fiscal year limitations, and shall consist of all monies received by the State Department of Education from private businesses, nonprofit organizations, and federally recognized Indian tribes or nations. All monies accruing to the credit of the fund are hereby appropriated and may be budgeted and expended by the State Department of Education for the purpose of improving reading outcomes in accordance with the Strong Readers Act or in accordance with other programs supporting this act. Expenditures from the fund shall be made upon warrants issued by the State Treasurer against claims filed as prescribed by law with the Director of the Office of Management and Enterprise Services for approval and payment.

B. Donors to the Strong Readers Revolving Fund shall designate a specific school, school district, or region to receive their donation. The State Department of Education shall distribute monies from the Strong Readers Revolving Fund in strict compliance with donor designations required by this subsection.

C. Monies in the Strong Readers Revolving Fund may be expended for implementation support services, teacher training, data integration, evaluation, reporting, micro-credential stipends and program fees, and professional learning, to support statewide MTSS implementation goals.

SECTION 10. It being immediately necessary for the preservation of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

Passed the Senate the 20th day of April, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the Senate

Passed the House of Representatives the 13th day of April, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the House
of Representatives

OFFICE OF THE GOVERNOR

Received by the Office of the Governor this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

By: _____

Approved by the Governor of the State of Oklahoma this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

Governor of the State of Oklahoma

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY OF STATE

Received by the Office of the Secretary of State this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

By: _____